

Adeptus Custodes — 'The Better Thing 2' Analysis

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Overview

THE BETTER THING 2 — Adeptus Custodes · Shield Host + Tharanatoi Hammerblow (Meta Slayers)

Shield Host (2 DP — mark + Ka'tah) + Tharanatoi Hammerblow (1 DP — the deep-strike Allarus hammer) = 3 DP

Priority Assets — a fast, durable elite army that takes and holds the priority objectives, deletes what contests them in melee, and grinds you out on quality.

2,000 / 2000 (Meta Slayers' build). Points are the app's (v912). ~40 models total. Legality of the key tech verified from data/bsdata/rules: Martial Ka'tah (army rule), Shield Host (Assemblage of Might + Martial Mastery), Tharanatoi Hammerblow (The Hammer Falls + Allarus enhancements/strats); Valerian/Blade Champion/Shield-Captain lead Custodian Guard/Wardens (verified).

A GOLDEN TIDE OF QUALITY — ~40 models that each shrug what kills whole squads. The core is durable character-led bricks (Valerian + Wardens, Blade Champion + Guard, Shield-Captain + Guard) that are all 2+/4++, T6 W3, and swing S7 AP-2 D2 Guardian spears (A5 EACH) — and the ARMY rule Martial Ka'tah stacks army-wide SUSTAINED or LETHAL Hits on that melee every round, while Shield Host's Assemblage of Might adds +1 to Wound vs a marked target for the character units. That turns already-brutal spears into a wall of auto-wounding, extra-hitting D2 attacks. Around it: a DEEP-STRIKE ALLARUS HAMMER (Tharanatoi Hammerblow — deep strike from Reserves / Rapid Ingress, re-roll charges on the turn they ingress, +1 T, re-roll wounds vs CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE = anti-elite/anti-tank), fast harassers (M10 Venatari jet-packs, M12 Vertus jetbikes with a mortal-wound bomb), and cheap Sisters of Silence (Prosecutors for actions/objectives, Witchseeker flamers for hordes + ANTI-PSYKER). It is durable, mobile, hits like a truck, and has answers to everything — its only real hole is being OUT-BODIED by a true horde, because ~40 elite models can only physically cover so much board.

Prevalence-weighted win rate: ~52%. The rebuilt sim scores the REAL 11E missions (your Force

Disposition is **Priority Assets**; each opponent's is taken from real list data, and the matrix hands each

side a different mission). The key finding: the biggest weighted drag is **not** the Orks body-hole but the

Purge-the-Foe matchups (Emperor's Children, T'au) — the matrix forces Priority-Assets Custodes

onto **Vital Link** (needs you to hold centre + steal the enemy home; hard for a non-castle-cracker) while

those armies get the strong **Destroyer's Wrath**. You out-*fight* them but lose the *mission*.

Matchups (Custodes = Priority Assets)

Faction / archetype	Opp disposition	You play	Win %	Read
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Emperor's Children — Frenzied Host / Coterie (Defiler + swarm)	Purge the Foe	Vital Link	47%	Coin-flip
Orks — Green Tide (~100 bodies)	Take and Hold	Secure Asset	31%	Unfavourable
Adeptus Mechanicus — Rad-Zone / Lords of the Forge gunline	Priority Assets	Sabotage	59%	Lean favourable
T'au Empire — Retaliation Cadre (fusion/rail alpha)	Purge the Foe	Vital Link	33%	Unfavourable
Necrons — Awakened Dynasty (C'tan + Wraiths)	Take and Hold	Secure Asset	55%	Lean favourable
Adeptus Custodes — the MIRROR (Shield Host / elite golden)	Take and Hold	Secure Asset	66%	Favourable
Blood Angels — Stormlance / Liberator jump alpha	Take and Hold	Secure Asset	75%	Favourable
Dark Angels — Deathwing Knights / Inner Circle	Priority Assets	Sabotage	57%	Lean favourable
Drukhari — Skysplinter Assault (fast splinter + lance)	Reconnaissance	Vanguard Operation	74%	Favourable
Astra Militarum — Steel Hammer superheavy / artillery	Priority Assets	Sabotage	61%	Lean favourable

Bands

Favourable: Adeptus Mechanicus (59%), Necrons (55%), Adeptus Custodes (66%), Blood Angels (75%), Dark Angels (57%), Drukhari (74%), Astra Militarum (61%)

Coin-flip / even: Emperor's Children (47%)

Unfavourable: Orks (31%), T'au Empire (33%)

The rules tapestry (DB/pack-verified)

Martial Ka'tah — the ARMY rule (Sustained OR Lethal, MELEE only)

FIGHT PHASE only. Each time a Custodes unit is selected to fight it picks the BEST stance for that target: DACATARAI ([SUSTAINED HITS 1]) or RENDAX ([LETHAL HITS]). Crossover (with Martial Mastery's crit-on-5+): the two are equal when you wound on 4+ (S=T); default to SUSTAINED, flip to LETHAL only when target Toughness > weapon Strength (wounding on 5+/6+). For the S7 Guardian spears: SUSTAINED vs T7 and below (most infantry/light vehicles), LETHAL vs T8+ (Knights, heavy vehicles, big monsters). Army-wide on every unit with this ability; Shield Host stacks on top.

Shield Host — Assemblage of Might (mark -> +1 wound)

Command phase: mark ONE enemy unit. Until your next Command phase, each model in an ADEPTUS CUSTODES CHARACTER unit gets +1 to WOUND vs it. Per Core Rule 19.01 an attached unit is a single unit for all rules purposes and gains CHARACTER, so this covers the WHOLE led brick (all 5 spears of Valerian+Wardens / Blade-Champion+Guard / Shield-Captain+Guard) AND any solo character — NOT the standalone Allarus (no attached leader = not a Character unit; they still get crit-5 + a stance + Slayers). Point the

mark at the durable thing you must crack and the bricks wound it on a much better roll.

Shield Host — Martial Mastery (crit-on-5+ / +1 AP)

Start of the battle round, pick ONE (army-wide until next round): (a) unmodified melee Hit of 5+ scores a CRITICAL HIT, or (b) +1 AP to all melee. Option (a) is the engine — crit-on-5+ roughly DOUBLES the Ka'tah proc rate: with RENDAX every 5+ auto-wounds ([Lethal]), with DACATARAI every 5+ throws an extra hit ([Sustained]). The Shield-Captain's MASTER OF THE STANCES then gives HIS unit BOTH stances for one fight (Sustained AND Lethal at once). NOTE: applies to every model with the Martial Ka'tah ability — so the Allarus benefit from crit-5 + stance too.

Tharanatoi Hammerblow — the deep-strike Allarus hammer

THE HAMMER FALLS: an ADEPTUS CUSTODES TERMINATOR unit that made an INGRESS MOVE this turn re-rolls charges. This list takes NO enhancements (no Mnemo-Locked Shrine Cipher), so the 5 Allarus arrive from Reserves (T2+) or via the core RAPID INGRESS stratagem at the end of the opponent's Movement phase — and re-roll the ~9" charge on the turn they ingress. SLAYERS OF TYRANTS (re-roll Wounds vs CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE) makes them a precision anti-elite/anti-tank delete; HARDENED RESOLVE (+1 T, 1CP) makes them a T8 rock; ELECTROEXORCIST SATURATION turns the Balistus launchers into D3+3 A anti-horde; UNLEASH THE LIONS splits them into 5 single-model action/board pieces.

Durability — the whole army is a rock

2+/4++ on EVERY model (T6 W3 Guard/Wardens, T7 W4/W5 Allarus/Vertus). Valerian's Golden Laurels (-1 AP to melee vs his unit) + Wardens' Feel No Pain + Resolute Will (-1 to wound vs S>T) make the anchor near-unkillable. AP-heavy shooting is blunted by the 4++; volume struggles against 2+. You out-LAST almost everything.

Speed + board control (the un-Custodes part)

M10 Venatari + M12 Vertus (Turbo +6") + deep-strike Allarus = a fast, flexible board game most Custodes lists lack. The jetbikes/jet-packs grab and flip objectives, the Vertus Quicksilver Execution drops mortals over a screen, and the Sisters of Silence (Prosecutors) do the cheap ACTIONS/secondaries a low-model army usually can't.

Sisters of Silence — anti-Psyker + cheap bodies

Prosecutors (2x) + Witchseekers give an elite army the CHEAP OC bodies + action-doers it normally can't afford, and the Sisters are ANTI-PSYKER (shut down enemy psychic + Witchseeker Torrent flamers auto-hit hordes). A clean answer to Thousand Sons/Grey Knights/psychic decks and a screen vs everyone.

The Emperor's Champions of the meta — kill priority

You have no shortage of quality; the discipline is TARGETING. Assemblage-mark the thing you MUST kill each turn; Ka'tah-stance to match (Lethal vs high-T, Sustained vs many/durable); send the Allarus into the enemy's biggest CHARACTER/MONSTER/VEHICLE (Slayers re-rolls wounds); Blade Champion Precisions an attached buff-character. Do NOT waste the Warden brick chasing chaff.

What genuinely beats it

(1) A TRUE HORDE (Orks) — ~40 elite models can't out-body ~100 and physically can't cover the board, so you get out-scored on primary even while winning every fight; (2) being out-ACTIONED by an evasive objective army if your bricks get bogged in the wrong fight. It has no bad DAMAGE or DURABILITY matchups — only a body-count / tempo ceiling.

Verified profiles & buffs

Piece	Profile / rule	Note
--- the melee engine (Guardian spears + Ka'tah) ---		
Custodian Guard / Warden / Allarus — Guardian Spear	S7 AP-2 D2 A5	the core; +[Sustained] or [Lethal] via Martial Ka'tah, +1 wound vs the Assemblage mark.
Blade Champion — Vaultswords	S7 AP-2 D2 A6 [PRECISION]	the character-assassin.
Vertus Praetor — Interceptor lance	S7 AP-2 D2 A5 [LANCE]	+1 to wound on the charge; fast (M12).
--- the buffs (from data/bsdata/rules) ---		
Martial Ka'tah (ARMY rule)	each fight: DACATARAI [Sustained Hits 1] or RENDAX [Lethal Hits]	army-wide melee tech, every unit, every fight.
Assemblage of Might (Shield Host)	mark 1 enemy unit -> CHARACTER units +1 to Wound vs it	point it at the thing you must crack.
The Hammer Falls (Tharanatoi Hammerblow)	an ingressed TERMINATOR unit re-rolls charges	the Allarus alpha (+ Slayers of Tyrants: re-roll Wounds vs CHAR/MON/VEH).
--- durability / speed ---		
Custodian Guard / Wardens	T6 W3 2+/4++ M6 OC2	Wardens add Feel No Pain; Valerian adds -1 AP to melee + FNP6+.
Venatari / Vertus	T6 W3 2+/M10 · T7 W5 2+/M12	the speed + board control most Custodes lists lack.

Bottom line

The Better Thing 2 is a TOP-TIER all-comers list — ~58-60% prevalence-weighted, with a very high floor: it has NO bad damage or durability matchup (2+/4++/FNP + Ka'tah + Assemblage out-fights everything), and it adds the speed + board control + anti-Psyker + cheap actions that most Custodes lists lack (Venatari/Vertus/Allarus + Sisters of Silence). Realistic 300+ GT: a strong positive record with a genuine top-tables run. Its ONE structural hole is a true HORDE — ~40 elite models can't out-body ~100 or cover the whole board, so Orks (and other true swarms) out-score it on primary even while it wins every fight. Everything else, it out-lasts and deletes. A genuinely nasty Meta-Slayers list — the horde matchup is the only thing to fear.